

LANGUAGE & TECHNOLOGY

Netflix Lakota

Inside the fight over a language that was nearly lost — and the tech that helped bring it back

BY LANCE ROBERTSON

Lonnie Flandreau, like many eight-year-olds, enjoys watching Batman cartoons after school. But unlike most kids his age, he knows the Dark Knight in his native language as *Ȟupákiglake Wiçaśta.* In this household in Spearfish, South Dakota, the default language setting on apps matches the one spoken around the kitchen table: Lakota. By all accounts, for a language that was on the verge of extinction a generation ago — and still appears on UNESCO's endangered list — this is a victory. According to tribal education officials, more children are growing up in Lakota-speaking homes today than at any point since the nineteenth century. But for some of the language advocates who spent decades fighting to keep Lakota alive, the victory is an uneasy one.

"Automatic translation has been a real blessing in a lot of ways," says Doreen Bordeaux, a retired language teacher on the Rosebud Indian Reservation. "The young people have everything in Lakota now. My granddaughter sings along to songs I've never heard, in a language I've spoken my



Doreen Bordeaux at her home on the Rosebud Indian Reservation.

whole life.” She pauses. “But sometimes the words come out and I think — who taught you to say it like that?”

The short answer is: nobody did. The cacophony of dubbed and translated voices being played on major streaming platforms is largely done automatically. While flagship content pieces for specific markets still get a degree of human oversight, the long tail of shows, songs, and livecasts are now processed through neural language models into the listener’s target format. For Lakota, and for dozens of other Indigenous languages, the translation data comes from the Global Indigenous Language Alliance, or GILA — a consortium of more than forty Indigenous nations founded in 2035 to collectively negotiate the terms under which their languages enter the commercial AI ecosystem. GILA’s model is deceptively simple: member nations contribute to a shared but sovereign corpus, and GILA licenses access to platforms in exchange for revenue that flows back to member communities. It is the first large-scale application of indigenous data sovereignty principles to the entertainment industry.

The Lakota that Doreen Bordeaux’s granddaughter sings along to was not, in most cases, spoken by a human being. It was generated — word by word, phoneme by phoneme — by a model trained on recordings that Bordeaux herself may have contributed to, decades ago, in a very different context. The corpus that powers GILA’s Lakota module traces its origins to what language advocates now refer to, with a mixture of pride and exhaustion, as “the recording years.”

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“It was a do-or-die time for us,” says Martin Eastman, a GILA technical liaison who is Sisseton-Wahpeton Dakota. Eastman spent his twenties on corpus projects at the University of Minnesota, arriving just as a new generation of digital tools was beginning to meet an old problem. “We were racing funerals,” he says. “Every month we lost someone who carried a dialect no one else spoke.”

This is the quiet work of language elicitation. Sitting with elders on porches and

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in pickup trucks, carrying recorders and paper coffee cups into tribal community centers. Work that is slow by nature. In languages like Lakota and Dakota, a single verb can carry what English needs a full sentence to express. Subject, object, tense, kinship, all compressed into one word. In the recording years, every form had to be taped and later transcribed and segmented by hand – no existing software could parse the morphology.

“You’d record an hour of conversation and spend a week pulling it apart,” Eastman says. “And then you’d drive back to ask why a certain word form was used. Sometimes she’d say, I don’t know why I say it that way. I just do.”

By the late 2020s, the tools were beginning to catch up. Researchers working on other Indigenous languages — Cree, Mohawk, Māori — were showing that the computational barriers were not insurmountable.

“The technical problems were getting solved,” Eastman says. “By the end of the decade, the real barriers were cultural. Who gets access to the recordings. On what terms. There were people who wanted to lock everything down — after the copyright disputes, I understood that. But we were losing speakers while we argued about access policies.”

Intertribal data compacts, decades of capacity building, and the arrival of platforms like CrowdCorpus began to pay off. “By 2027 we had people logging Lakota recordings on their phones on the way to work,” Eastman says. “It wasn’t the cleanest quality. But it was data.” Within a few years, communities had recorded ten times more speech than in all the years before. The result was a corpus large enough, for the first time, to support the kind of generative language models that English and Mandarin had had for years.

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“I think it’s a mistake,” says Gerald Thompson, a language instructor at Oglala Lakota College on the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation. Thompson has taught Lakota for nearly twenty years. He is not opposed to technology — he helped develop early curriculum materials for the language apps that became standard in reservation schools. But he has watched the rise of auto-translated content with growing unease.



Gerald Thompson in the hallway at Oglala Lakota College, Pine Ridge Indian Reservation

“The models are better than they used to be,” he says. “Ten years ago it was nonsense. Now it’s — It’s almost right. The grammar is mostly correct. But it’s flattening everything. The dialects are disappearing into one voice. The gendered forms get mixed up. Kinship terms are used out of context.”

What troubles Thompson most is not the surface errors but the architecture be-

neath them. His students, he says, produce sentences that are Lakota words arranged around English ideas. “Greetings that don’t exist in the language. Apologies that don’t work the way we apologize. The models learned the words from recordings but they learned how to think from English.”

And then there is the question of ownership. The GILA module is built on a standard that half the communities never agreed to. “My elders hear it and say, that’s not how we talk. That’s not our Lakota.” He shrugs. “It’s Netflix Lakota.”

“That’s not our Lakota. It’s Netflix Lakota.”

GERALD THOMPSON

Bordeaux, for her part, is less certain than Thompson that the shift is entirely new. “Languages change,” she says. “New words get added. Old ones fall out of use. That’s always happened.” She pauses. “But it used to be us doing the adapting.”

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From his office at the University of Minnesota, where he still holds a research appointment, Eastman has been watching the CrowdCorpus data shift. “Speakers today come home and talk to their assistants in Lakota,” he says. “They watch foreign true crime shows translated on the fly. When Love Ito drops a new album, Spotify has it in Lakota within the hour. The language is everywhere now. That was the whole point.”

But the data coming in now, he says, doesn’t look like what they recorded in the twenties. The new speakers — the kids who grew up on dubbed content — are using new forms. Constructions that didn’t exist before the module generated them. “Some of them are beautiful, actually. Elegant. But they didn’t come from anyone.”



Martin Eastman at his office at the University of Minnesota.

He pulls up a recent example. A compound the model coined to translate a line from a dating show, one of those “I’m not here to make friends” confessionals. *“Takúye olé waú šni,”* Eastman says. “Something like, ‘I didn’t come seeking relatives.’” He laughs. “In English, it’s a throwaway phrase. In Lakota, it sounds like you’re disavowing your family. The kids thought it was the funniest thing they’d ever heard,” Eastman says. “Now you hear it at basketball games. Someone takes a bad shot and the whole bench yells it.”

But the phrase also showed up in the CrowdCorpus logs, tagged by contributors as common usage, with no source attribution. “We had a meeting last spring about whether to flag model-generated coinages in the corpus,” Eastman says. “Someone suggested we tag them so they don’t feed back into the training data. But by the time we had the meeting, half of them were already in common use. You can’t untag a word that people are already speaking.”

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Tamara Taylor is twenty-three and teaches first grade at a language nest on Pine Ridge. She is not, she says, as worried as some of the older teachers.

“I grew up in immersion. No English before lunch — Mrs. Frazier, she was intense.” She laughs. “My mom, all she had



Tamara Taylor at a language nest on the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation.

in Lakota was the Avengers movie and like, twenty episodes of Berenstain Bears. By the time I was in school, we could come home and just put on whatever we wanted and keep hearing the language. That's huge. People don't get how huge that is."

Her grandparents, she says, had Lakota beaten out of them in boarding school. They never taught it to her mother. "But they'd speak it to each other when they didn't want the kids to know what they were saying." She pauses. "So my mom grew up hearing Lakota as this secret adult language. Something you weren't supposed to understand."

> *"A language that isn't changing is a language that isn't being spoken anymore."*
>
> TAMARA TAYLOR

Now, she says, her first-graders use it to tell on each other.

She's heard Gerald Thompson's criticisms. She's less concerned. "What would worry me is if our enrollment was dropping," she says. "What would worry me is if I wasn't hearing laughing and teasing in the hallways in Lakota. So there's new coinages and memes coming in faster than we can keep up with." She shrugs. "I don't know if that's a problem."

Still, she has started keeping a list on her phone. Words her students use that she can't find in any textbook or trace to any recording. "I'll correct bad grammar when I hear it," she says. "But if there's a new phrase that works, I'm okay with that. I just want to know where they're coming from." She keeps the list, she says, because the new words move fast. "Sometimes I ask around and nobody's heard of them. And then six months later everyone's saying it. A language that isn't changing is a language that isn't being spoken anymore."

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In Germany, a fascination with Plains cultures stretching back more than a century had already produced a community of

dedicated Lakota learners long before any content was dubbed. The roots are deep and strange: Karl May's Winnetou novels, first published in the 1890s, made fictional Plains warriors into German folk heroes. Buffalo Bill's touring shows brought Lakota performers to Berlin in the same decade. By the early twentieth century there were hobbyist clubs across the country — the first founded in Munich in 1913 — devoted to studying and reenacting Plains Indian life. Some specialized in Lakota specifically. Today, estimates put the number of active hobbyists in the tens of thousands, organized across hundreds of clubs from Karlsruhe to Dresden. It is a practice that Indigenous scholars have long criticized for the stereotypical lens through which it reads Native cultures. But it has also, over the decades, produced a small number of serious language learners — people whose interest outlasted the costumes.

"I used to feel some kind of way about it," Eastman says. "You do this work for twenty years and then you meet a Berliner who's conversationally fluent and you think, how?" He shakes his head. "Honestly, I used to get mad about this kind of stuff. But now I feel like, if outsiders are that motivated to learn this language, that just inspires me to work harder on it myself. The more the merrier."

Not everyone shares Eastman's equanimity. The question of who a revived language belongs to — whether outsiders can meaningfully participate in its revival, or whether their participation changes something fundamental about what is being revived — has followed Indigenous language movements for decades. For most of that history, it was an academic question. There weren't enough outsiders learning Lakota for it to matter. Now there are.

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For years, GILA maintained a committee of fluent speakers tasked with coining new Lakota words. It was necessary work. There were not enough speakers in regular contact for new words to emerge casually, in conversation, without anyone having to decide.

Committee members say the meetings feel different now. New word forms arrive already in use. Some were generated by the models and carried into daily speech through dubbed songs, shows, and streams. Some were coined by children in immersion classrooms describing their everyday lives. The committee reviews them, but it is no longer always clear what the review is for.

The committee still meets once a year. The platforms generate new Lakota every day. ***V***

Lance Robertson is a contributing writer at Voxlantic. *He writes about AI, language, and Indigenous data sovereignty.*

About This Work

Netflix Lakota is a work of speculative journalism set in 2044. It is meant to dramatize an Indigenous language revitalization future where everything has gone right: funding, immersion nest programs, respected data sovereignty protocols, sustained institutional commitment — and a community-built corpus large enough to train AI. This story takes that best case scenario seriously, and then asks what happens next.

Efforts to dub popular media into Indigenous languages — the Navajo dub of Star Wars in 2013, and the Ojibwe Star Wars and Lakota Avengers dubs in 2024 — are labor-intensive community achievements. Taking inspiration from these real-life projects, I wondered what would happen if AI could create these kinds of translations without human intervention at all. The phrase “Netflix Lakota” burrowed into my thinking, and once it did, the story started to take shape.

I’m a citizen of the Sisseton-Wahpeton Oyate, a tribal nation in South Dakota, and early in my own Dakota/Lakota language journey. This piece was developed in a course at UC San Diego, in which we were asked to think speculatively about futures that intersect with our own biographies.

In developing this piece, I was encouraged to move my AI translation timelines up. I did, though I believe the political and cultural questions will take longer than the technology to resolve. I was also encouraged to start prototyping the tools I was writing about. To that end I’ve built two things: an evaluation of frontier LLM capability[1] to translate Lakota as of early 2026, which found that no frontier model can yet reliably translate the language, and UX wireframes for CrowdCorpus[2], the community-governed corpus building tool at the heart of my story.

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1. https://github.com/robotson/lakota-translation-benchmark
2. https://github.com/robotson/crowd-corpus-proto

Speculative Timeline

2027 — **CrowdCorpus Goes Live**
A community-governed platform for collecting and reviewing Indigenous language recordings launches with mobile app support. Lakota contributions surge.

2029 — **Lakota ASR Tools**
Automatic speech recognition models trained on CrowdCorpus recordings enable rapid transcription. The archive grows faster than manual processing ever allowed.

2031 — **Corpus Critical Mass**
CrowdCorpus has enough Lakota data to train sovereign language models.

2032 — **Auto-Dubbing Goes Mainstream**
Real-time translation between major languages becomes standard on streaming platforms. Low-resource languages remain unsupported.

2033 — **Synthetic Data Flywheel**
Sovereign Lakota models begin generating synthetic training data, accelerating corpus growth beyond what human recording alone could sustain.

2035 — **GILA Founded**
The Global Indigenous Language Alliance — a consortium of more than forty Indigenous nations — is established to collectively negotiate the terms under which their languages enter the commercial AI ecosystem. Member nations contribute to a shared but sovereign corpus.

2038 — **GILA Licensing Begins**
GILA licenses a suite of Indigenous language modules — including Lakota — to major streaming and entertainment platforms.

2044 — **Netflix Lakota**
A generation raised on auto-dubbed Lakota content is now old enough to speak it back.